TEACHER GUIDE | LESSON 12

1 Corinthians Part 4

Resurrection Hope

BIG IDEA Christ's bodily resurrection guarantees the resurrection of his people and makes steadfast service worthwhile.

Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- state the gospel Paul received and passed on and explain why the resurrection witnesses matter;
- show why Christianity collapses if Christ was not bodily raised;
- explain how Christ as firstfruits guarantees the resurrection of those who belong to him;
- describe the resurrection body as continuous with the present body yet transformed, imperishable, and empowered by the Spirit; and
- connect future resurrection to steadfast service, generosity, courage, strength, and love in the present.

Lesson at a glance

TIME	MOVEMENT
0:00-5:00	Opening question, prayer, and connection to Lesson 11
5:00-13:00	The gospel received and witnessed - 15:1-11
13:00-20:00	If Christ has not been raised - 15:12-19
20:00-28:00	Firstfruits and the defeat of death - 15:20-28
28:00-39:00	The resurrection body - 15:35-49
39:00-45:00	Mystery, victory, and steadfast work - 15:50-58
45:00-50:00	Final charge, discussion, homework, and prayer - chapter 16

Before class

Write on the board: If death really has been defeated, what should look different in the way Christians live now?

Controlling question: How does Christ's bodily resurrection guarantee the resurrection of his people and make steadfast service worthwhile?

Mark 1 Corinthians 15:1-8, 12-28, 35-58 and 16:13-14. Ask one reader to be prepared for the shorter readings. Summarize rather than read every verse so the class can follow Paul's argument.

PROTECT THE SPINE Required: Paul's gospel summary, the consequences if Christ was not raised, Christ as firstfruits, the nature of the resurrection body, and the therefore of 15:58. Brief leader notes only unless asked: baptism for the dead and the Son's subjection to the Father. Safely omit: cataloging every proposed interpretation of 15:29, constructing a detailed end-times chart, and speculation about the physics or appearance of resurrection bodies.

The whole lesson in one claim

Paul does not offer resurrection as a comforting symbol or an optional doctrine. If Christ remained dead, the gospel is false, sin still condemns, Christian witness is dishonest, and believers have no lasting hope. But Christ has been raised. His resurrection is the firstfruits of the harvest to come, so those who belong to him will be raised, death will be defeated, and work done in the Lord is never wasted.

CENTRAL LINE The resurrection is not an appendix to the gospel. It is God's victory in Christ, the guarantee of our future, and the reason faithful service matters now.

1. CORE The gospel received and witnessed

Read 15:1-8. The language of receiving and passing on was used for carefully transmitting an established body of teaching. Paul reminds the Corinthians of the message they had received, on which they stood, and through which they were being saved. The material in verses 3-7 reaches back to the earliest Christian proclamation rather than emerging as a late legend.

THE GOSPEL PAUL RECEIVED	WHY IT MATTERS
Christ died for our sins	His death addresses guilt and fulfills God's saving purpose in Scripture.
He was buried	Jesus truly died; the claim is not merely that his influence or cause continued.
He was raised on the third day	God acted bodily and decisively, also in fulfillment of Scripture.
He appeared to witnesses	The risen Christ was encountered by Peter, the Twelve, more than five hundred, James, the apostles, and Paul.

Use the witness list as both apostolic testimony and historical evidence. Paul names individuals and a large group, notes that many remained alive, and includes his own encounter. The point is not that a list can force faith, but that Christian faith is publicly anchored in what God did in history. Paul's former persecution and present apostleship display the same grace he proclaims.

2. CORE If Christ has not been raised

Read 15:12-19. Some Corinthians apparently affirmed Christ's resurrection while denying the future resurrection of believers. Paul refuses that separation. If bodily resurrection is impossible, then Christ was not raised either. He repeats the consequences so no one can treat resurrection as a secondary issue.

IF CHRIST WAS NOT RAISED	THEN
Apostolic preaching	is empty and misrepresents God.
Christian faith	is futile because its central claim is false.
The problem of sin	remains; Christ's saving work has not achieved its promised victory.
Believers who have died	have perished rather than entered resurrection life.
Christian hope	is limited to this life, making costly faithfulness pitiable rather than wise.

3. CORE Firstfruits and the final enemy

Verse 20 reverses the entire argument: 'But Christ has indeed been raised from the dead.' Firstfruits were the opening portion of a harvest, both a sample and a pledge of what would follow. Christ is not merely the first isolated person to survive death. His resurrection begins the harvest and shows the kind of life his people will receive.

Paul contrasts two representative heads. In Adam, humanity shares sin, mortality, and death. Those who belong to Christ share the life of the risen Christ and will be raised at his coming. The contrast is not universal salvation regardless of faith; Paul identifies the promised company as 'those who belong to him' (15:23).

PAUL'S BROAD SEQUENCE	TEXT
Christ has already been raised as firstfruits	15:20, 23
At Christ's coming, those who belong to him are raised	15:23
Christ brings every hostile rule, authority, and power to nothing	15:24-25
The last enemy, death, is destroyed	15:26
The completed kingdom is presented to the Father so God is all in all	15:24, 28

Teach this as a broad theological sequence, not a complete end-times chart. The passage does not settle the timing of the millennium or every interval between events. Its unmistakable destination is the reign of God and the destruction of death.

THE SON SUBJECTED TO THE FATHER Verse 28 describes the completion of Christ's saving mission and his willing relation to the Father, not inferiority in divine nature. The Son defeats every enemy and presents the completed kingdom to the Father. The triune God reigns without rival; Christ does not cease to be divine or cease to reign. Calvin's helpful emphasis is that Christ's mediatorial work reaches its appointed goal and redeemed creation beholds God's reign in its fullness.

A disputed text that should remain disputed

In 15:29 Paul asks about people being 'baptized for the dead.' The practice is uncertain. One leading view is that some Corinthians underwent baptism on behalf of believers who died before baptism; Paul can use their practice in an argument without approving or commanding it. Another view takes 'the dead' as the mortal bodies of living believers: baptism expresses hope for bodies destined to die and rise. Many other proposals exist, and none commands consensus. State only what is clear: Paul uses a practice familiar to Corinth to expose the inconsistency of denying resurrection. The verse cannot establish salvation by proxy, which contradicts the New Testament's call to personal faith in Christ.

4. CORE What kind of body will be raised

Read 15:35-49. Paul answers two questions: How are the dead raised, and with what kind of body? The seed analogy holds continuity and transformation together. The plant comes from the seed, yet God gives it a form fitted for its new life. Creation already displays God's power to give different bodies suited to different realms. The resurrection body is truly ours, but it is not merely the present body restarted.

SOWN	RAISED	PAUL'S POINT
Perishable	Imperishable	No longer subject to decay or death
In dishonor	In glory	Restored to the splendor God intends
In weakness	In power	No longer marked by mortal frailty
A natural body	A spiritual body	Fully embodied life fitted and empowered by God's Spirit
Bearing Adam's image	Bearing Christ's image	Conformed to the risen man from heaven

A 'spiritual body' is not a ghost or an immaterial soul. Paul deliberately keeps the word body. 'Natural' and 'spiritual' describe the source and quality of life: the present body belongs to mortal life inherited from Adam; the resurrection body is transformed for imperishable life under the power of the Spirit. Likewise, 'flesh and blood cannot inherit the

kingdom' means mortal, corruptible humanity cannot enter God's final kingdom unchanged. It does not deny bodily resurrection; it explains why transformation is necessary.

5. CORE Death swallowed up in victory

Read 15:50-58. Paul reveals a mystery: not every believer will die before Christ returns, but every believer must be changed. The dead are raised imperishable, and living believers are transformed instantly at the final trumpet. Resurrection and transformation clothe the mortal with immortality. Death loses its sting because Christ has dealt with sin, and sin's condemning power is exposed through the law. God gives the victory through Jesus Christ.

DO NOT RUSH PAST THEREFORE Verse 58 is Paul's pastoral destination. Because resurrection is certain, believers can stand firm, refuse to be moved from the gospel, and give themselves fully to the Lord's work. The work may be hidden, difficult, or unfinished, but it is not in vain because death does not have the final word.

Chapter 16 Resurrection hope becomes ordinary faithfulness

Chapter 16 brings resurrection hope down to earth. The Corinthians are to give regularly and responsibly for believers in need, support faithful workers, recognize dependable servants, and maintain loving relationships across churches. Paul's closing commands summarize the letter: be alert, stand firm in the faith, be courageous, be strong, and do everything in love (16:13-14). Strength without love becomes Corinthian pride; love without firmness becomes sentimentality. Gospel courage holds both together.

The Gospel Then and Now

MOVEMENT	CHURCH APPLICATION
Church claim then	Some Corinthians tried to retain Christian faith while denying the future bodily resurrection of believers.
Church temptation now	We can reduce resurrection to a symbol, imagine salvation as escape from embodiment, or live as though present work ends at death.
Gospel-shaped hope	Because Christ was bodily raised, believers await transformed embodied life and serve now with steadiness, courage, generosity, and love.

Discussion

1. Why does Paul treat bodily resurrection as essential to the gospel rather than a secondary doctrine?
2. Which consequence in 15:12-19 most clearly shows what would collapse if Christ was not raised?
3. How does the image of firstfruits give more confidence than simply saying that life continues after death?
4. What misunderstandings are corrected by Paul's phrase 'spiritual body'?
5. Where are Christians tempted to believe that faithful work is pointless or wasted?
6. How should resurrection hope shape generosity, courage, strength, and love in the church this week?

Likely rabbit trails

The exact date of the creed in verses 3-7; attempting to identify all five hundred witnesses; harmonizing every resurrection appearance; the millennium; universal salvation; more than forty interpretations of baptism for the dead; whether resurrected people look a certain age; cremation; organ donation; and detailed rapture systems. Answer what is necessary, then return to Paul's line: Christ was raised, his people will be raised, death will be defeated, and labor in the Lord is not in vain.

Leader preparation

Primary sources used in these notes: Life Application Bible Commentary New Testament, sections on 1 Corinthians 15-16; ESV Study Bible, notes on 1 Corinthians 15:3-6, 20, and 29; NIV Cultural Backgrounds Study Bible, notes on 1 Corinthians 15:3-7 and 12-19; and John Calvin, Commentary on 1 Corinthians 15:28.

ECO connection: Essential Tenet II.B, the incarnation and bodily resurrection of Jesus Christ, and III.A, God's grace in Christ. Official text: eco-pres.org/constitution/

Before Lesson 13: Read 2 Corinthians 1-7. Mark where Paul connects suffering, weakness, comfort, integrity, reconciliation, and the power of God.